

We can be such snobs about master-planned communities. These new postcodes were typically sweeping dust bowls owned by state governments and released to developers to create new housing. There are positives and pitfalls to buying on the urban lip; the cookie-cutter, Legoland approach of these projects has evolved, and these days there are environmentally friendly builds designed by leading architects, some along the coast, as well as the ever-popular zones on the outskirts of cities.

The property spruik ‘Just a short stroll to ...’ has never carried more weight. Even the Heart Foundation is weighing in to the planning stage of these communities, sharing guidelines to help make these growth zones – sometimes called ‘greenfield estate’ – more phys-ed friendly. This is a positive step, because new estates have long been mired by the need for cars. Research by RMIT has found that good planning and design requirements for new estates are well-connected bike and walking paths, public transport connections and destinations where residents can meet.

So, you don’t need to live close to the city to get a daily dose of exercise and relish verdant spaces. But you should look at the amenities on offer, such as parks, cafés, football ovals, schools, public transport and shops. Community groups exist in these new estates to advocate for better amenities. Get in touch with them during your search and find out what the developer has promised that has been delivered, and what has been delayed or overlooked. You can also contact your state’s planning department to check the status of amenities that the developer and government are promising for your chosen housing estate.

You may buy the house already constructed, from a selection of designs, or buy the plot of land and wait for the property to be built. A technical difference between buying an established home and a house-and-land bundle is the way the mortgage is configured. With an established home, you’ll have a single loan, but with a package deal, you’ll take out a separate construction loan, given to you in increments, to pay for each stage of the build of your dream home. In some cases, these loans can be rolled into one. First home buyers can also score a grant, and/or stamp duty savings (see the end of Step 3 for more details).

Be mindful that if you’re eligible for a low-deposit deal by a housing estate developer – sale contracts have been known to be offered to first home buyers for as little as a \$2000 deposit – you will need to be certain